

# Reading comprehension

## COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

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### What You'll Learn

Reading comprehension (RC) tests whether a candidate can extract main ideas, tone, and specific facts from a passage accurately and quickly — under placement-test time pressure, the real skill being tested is disciplined reading strategy and answer elimination, not raw reading speed or vocabulary alone. The most common way strong readers still lose marks is answering from a vague memory of the passage instead of returning to the specific line the question is based on, and falling for options that are 'too broad,' 'too narrow,' or a plausible-sounding statement the passage never actually made. This sub-module covers skimming vs detailed reading strategy, identifying main idea and tone, distinguishing directly-stated facts from valid inferences, vocabulary-in-context questions, author's purpose, time budgeting for an RC set, and the classic wrong-answer patterns to eliminate quickly.

### 1. Skimming vs Detailed Reading Strategy

Skim the passage first (30-45 seconds) to grasp its overall structure and main idea, then read each question and return to the specific relevant portion of the passage for detailed reading — reading every word closely on the first pass wastes time on details that may not even be asked about.

- Passage: 'Over the last decade, renewable energy costs have fallen sharply, with solar panel prices dropping nearly 80%. This decline has made solar competitive with fossil fuels in many regions, even without subsidies.' A 30-second skim is enough to identify the main idea: falling solar costs have made it price-competitive with fossil fuels.

### 2. Identifying Main Idea and Tone

The main idea is usually stated or strongly implied in the first or last sentence of a paragraph; tone is judged from specific word choices (e.g., 'sharply', 'remarkably' suggest a more emphatic, positive tone than neutral factual reporting would use).

- In the solar-energy passage above, words like 'sharply' and 'competitive... even without subsidies' signal an informative, mildly optimistic tone — not a critical or skeptical one.

### 3. Directly-Stated Facts vs Valid Inferences

A direct question can be answered by pointing to an exact sentence in the passage; an inference question asks for something reasonably implied but never explicitly stated — inference answers must be strongly supported by the text, not merely 'possible.'

- Direct question: 'By how much have solar prices dropped?' Answer: nearly 80% (explicitly stated). Inference question: 'What can be inferred about future solar adoption?' Reasonable inference: adoption is likely to increase further, since solar is now price-competitive without subsidies — this isn't stated outright but follows directly from what is.

### 4. Vocabulary-in-Context Questions

These ask for a word's meaning AS USED in the passage, which may differ from its most common dictionary definition — always re-read the sentence containing the word and substitute each answer option back in to see which preserves the sentence's meaning.

- In the passage, 'sharply' (as in 'costs have fallen sharply') means 'significantly/steeply,' not the more literal sense of 'in a sharp, pointed manner.'

### 5. Author's Purpose and Passage Type

Distinguish whether a passage is primarily informative (reporting facts neutrally), persuasive (arguing for a viewpoint), or descriptive/narrative — this affects how to interpret tone questions and which conclusions the passage actually supports versus merely mentions.

### 6. Time Management for an RC Set

A typical passage with 5 questions should take roughly 6-7 minutes total: about 60-90 seconds to skim-read the passage, then roughly 45-60 seconds per question including the time to re-locate the relevant sentence and eliminate wrong options.

### 7. Elimination Strategy for Tricky Options

Most wrong options in RC fall into recognizable patterns: too broad (goes beyond what the passage actually claims), too narrow (true but misses the passage's main point), reverses the passage's actual claim, or introduces information never mentioned at all — scanning options for these patterns before re-checking the passage often eliminates 2-3 options immediately.

- For a question on the solar passage asking 'what does the passage suggest', an option claiming solar is now CHEAPER than fossil fuels everywhere is too broad (the passage says 'competitive in many regions', not universally cheaper) — a classic eliminable overreach.

### Common Pitfalls

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- Reading every word of the passage in painstaking detail on the first pass instead of skimming for structure first.

- Answering from a vague memory of the passage instead of returning to the exact relevant sentence for each question.
- Selecting an inference option that is merely 'possible' rather than one strongly and directly supported by the passage's actual wording.
- Choosing a vocabulary-in-context answer based on the word's most common dictionary meaning instead of its meaning in that specific sentence.
- Selecting an option that is 'too broad' — technically related to the passage but overstating what it actually claims.
- Running out of time on early passages by over-analyzing every line instead of allocating a fixed time budget per passage.

## Key Takeaways

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- Skim first for structure and main idea (30-60 seconds), then return to specific lines only as each question requires.
- Inference answers must be strongly supported by the text, not merely plausible or consistent with it.
- Vocabulary-in-context questions require substituting the word's contextual meaning, not its default dictionary sense.
- Watch for 'too broad,' 'too narrow,' 'reversed,' and 'not mentioned' as the four classic wrong-answer patterns.
- Budget roughly 45-60 seconds per question after the initial skim, and don't let one passage consume the whole section's time.
- Author's tone is judged from specific word choices, not from the topic of the passage alone.

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<https://www.indiabix.com/verbal-ability/comprehension/>

### GeeksforGeeks — Verbal Ability Questions and Answers

<https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/verbal-ability-questions-and-answers/>